

Four days, 18 decks, and Robert Downey Jr — Disney Cruise Line's largest ship makes its Asia debut with the longest roller-coaster at sea **P4**

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pick of the week



A breezy summer

A celebration of craft unfolds in Raw Mango's Summer collection, The Sun Returns, where Venkatgiri cotton, satin silk, Chanderi, organza and tissue shape sun-ready silhouettes. Whites, indigos and vibrant hues meet chevrons and archival butas, while fluid kurtas, kaftans and draped saris are finished with light embroidery, meena and appliqué.

The collection is available online and across stores in different cities.



Meet Payal Pratap

Designer Payal Pratap unveils her Spring Summer 2026 collection, Wildflower Soul, an ode to quiet living. Inspired by daily home scenes like morning light across old walls, and music drifting through open windows, the collection features fluid silhouettes, cottons and linens, florals and cross-stitch embroidery. Gingham checks add nostalgic charm, with easy separates. Meet the designer on March 28 at Collage, Rutland Gate. The collection is on till May.



Cry me a river

Turn your memories into music at If My Life Were A Song, a spoken-word open mic where lyrics meet lived moments. From teenage anthems to heartbreak tracks, unpack the songs that shaped us all — through poetry, storytelling, or quiet reflection. Whether you perform or just listen, expect an evening of nostalgia, connection, and shared emotion.

On March 28, from 6.30pm to 8.30pm, at Backyard, Adyar. Entry ₹236



Meet the makers

By Hand From The Heart brings together emerging labels, indie designers, and artisanal brands along with its creators. On display are clothes from Soleilclo, jewellery by Unbent Jewellery, pieces from The Wave Ceramics, lifestyle finds by Back Home Company, and bites from Shmoozie's Hand-Crafted Ice Creams, among others. On March 21 and 22 from 10am to 8pm, at Primrose, 131 Luz Church Road, Mylapore.

ILLUSTRATION: SAKI



THE NAKED TRUTH

Same people, different apps

When swipes, mixers and algorithms all lead back to the same set of strangers

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A friend in Mumbai recently told me she had four different encounters with the same man without ever quite dating him. The first time he appeared on Tinder, where they matched and exchanged a handful of messages briefly before the conversation dissolved in the usual way. Several months later he reappeared on Bumble,

where they politely pretended not to notice the prior encounter. The third sighting happened at a friend's birthday party in Bandra, at which point they recognised each other with the weary warmth of colleagues who have met at too many conferences. The fourth time he showed up at a curated dinner for singles. "At that point," she said, "we just laughed. It felt like the universe was running a long-term social experiment to ensure we keep bumping into each other." Spend enough time on dating

apps and this peculiar sense of rotation becomes difficult to ignore. Technology promises the thrill of infinite possibilities, but the longer you remain on these apps, the more they begin to resemble a dinner party with a persistent guest list. But this is not how the system is supposed to feel. Tinder has repeatedly described India as one of its fastest-growing markets and says Gen Z now makes up more than half of its global membership, with Indian cities contributing significantly to that

growth. Bumble's annual India Dating Trends report also notes that dating apps have become a mainstream way for young Indians to meet partners, particularly in urban centres where social lives revolve around work, gyms, cafés and the occasional overambitious house party, which has consistently been highlighted across the 2023 and 2024 editions. Bumble's user research has found that most singles prefer partners with similar educational backgrounds, professions and lifestyles. Algorithms designed to maximise compatibility tend to filter for exactly those characteristics. In cities like Mumbai and Bengaluru, where professional circles overlap with surprising efficiency, this means the same clusters of lawyers, consultants, designers and founders repeatedly encountering each other in slightly different digital arrangements. Perhaps this is why many singles now express a growing enthusiasm for meeting people offline. A Bumble survey released late 2024 mentioned that a majority of Indian users would prefer to meet in person fairly early in the process rather than continue long conversations over text. The industry has responded accordingly. Members-only platform The League, which recently launched in India, offers users a small set of curated matches each day and hosts invitation-only gatherings for members. Communities such as Offline by Happy Hour organise singles mixers in Mumbai and Bengaluru, while formats like Stranger Conversations dinners invite people, who have never met before, to sit down together for an evening of conversation. The idea is disarmingly optimistic: remove the screens and restore the chemistry.

Whether novelty follows is another matter.

Here we go again

A recently divorced woman in Delhi told me she downloaded a dating app earlier this year after weeks of encouragement from her friends. In her early 40s and the mother of two, she had managed to avoid the entire ecosystem of swipes and prompts until recently. Within a few days she received a message from a young man whose name seemed oddly familiar. When she opened his profile photo, she recognised him immediately. He was the son of a colleague, and 22; someone she had met briefly at an office gathering years earlier when his parents had brought him along. "He wrote, 'Hey, you seem interesting. Want to grab coffee?'" she said. "And I was thinking, I've eaten dinner with your parents."

The young man, she suspects, had no idea who she was. The experience left her faintly rattled. "I thought the pool would be large," she said. "I didn't expect to run into my colleague's child."

Elsewhere the overlaps are no less awkward. A consultant in Jaipur told me about attending a curated singles mixer only to discover that one of the attendees was someone she had dated briefly several years earlier. "I had ghosted him," she admitted with admirable frankness. Unfortunately, he remembered the evening rather differently. "He came up and said, 'You never replied to my last message.'" She took a sip of her drink before answering. "And I said, 'Yes. That was the reply.'"

For all the technology surrounding modern dating — algorithms, curated matches and invitation-only mixers — the social networks beneath it remain stubbornly human. What you often encounter instead is a cast of familiar characters, circulating patiently through the system, waiting for their next reappearance.

A fortnightly guide to love in the age of bare minimum



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At Jehan Numa Palace in Bhopal, I am shown a mango tree said to be nearly 100 years old. A few years ago, it took a direct lightning strike and had to be trimmed; since then, it yields barely a dozen mangoes each season, a few claimed by the staff while the rest find their way into the kitchen. Dinner, as it turns out, is served under this very tree.

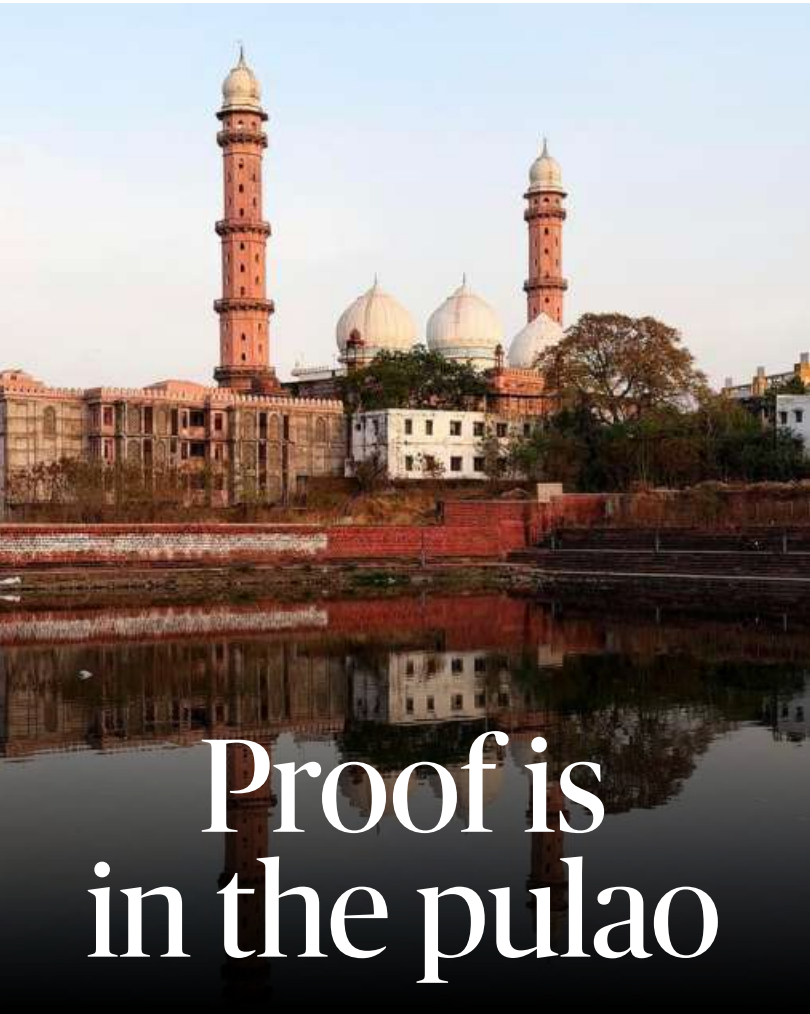
The setting is not incidental. General Obaidullah Khan — the second son of Nawab Sultan Jahan Begum and the last of its remarkable line of female sovereigns, known for administrative reforms — served as Commander-in-Chief of the Bhopal State Forces. Under him, time outdoors was woven into daily life. Hunting expeditions were common, and meals were often taken under trees, with family and guests gathering in the open after long hours outside. Sitting here now feels like a continuation of that habit.

The meal, The General's Table, a 20-course feast that people can sign up for (prices vary according to the season), draws from the kitchens of Bhopal's former royals. The courses move through kebabs, curries, rice dishes and desserts, with a certain ease.

"Bhopal is a relatively late state if you compare it to places like Hyderabad or Lucknow," says Faiz Rashid, managing director, Jehan Numa Group, and great-grandson of General Obaidullah. Founded in the early 18th Century by the Afghan



ruler Dost Mohammad Khan, its food reflects that lineage, layered with influences from regions like present-day Uttar Pradesh, brought in through migration and marriage. Some of the dishes served here reappear, in simpler form, on Eid tables. A pulao often anchors the



Proof is in the pulao

From Afghan-influenced royal cuisine to Bohra thaal traditions and Memon biryani in Mumbai, here is a detailed look at how Eid food varies across regions and communities in India

meal — sometimes an Afghan-style preparation — served with green chicken rizala (with coriander dominating the dish), mutton korma, kebabs and vegetables. There is no singular 'Bhopali biryani'; recipes tend to remain familial, shaped over time. Preparations like filfora, a coarser minced meat dish somewhere between keema and pasanda, point back to an outdoor cooking tradition, while dishes like makhania korma and smoked aubergine sit alongside. Desserts follow the same logic. There is sheer khurma, chana dal halwa, and shahi tukda, all familiar across North India but noticeably lighter here, less sweet and more balanced. "While dining under a tree is not

typically an Eid practice in itself, it sets the tone for a more informal gathering," says Faiz.

Sense of community

In Kolkata, among the Dawoodi Bohra community, the emphasis shifts to structure. The morning begins at the masjid with Eid namaz and the khutba, after which people gather around the thaal, a large communal platter seating about eight. A kharak (dried date) marks the start, followed by greetings, before the meal settles into place. Everything is arranged simply but with care. "A pinch of salt begins the meal, followed by sheer khurma, nihari with shirmal or poories, and akoori, softly spiced scrambled eggs. One fruit is always part of the

(Clockwise from far left) Yakhni pulao; Taj-ul-Masjid in Bhopal; General Obaidullah; bone marrow haleem at Bombay Canteen; Shahjahan Begum; and, sheer khurma. THE BOHRI KITCHEN, GETTY IMAGES/ISTOCK AND SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



spread, and portions are taken with care so nothing is wasted. Volunteers move between groups, refilling dishes, while tea arrives with the familiar choice: *phikki* (savoury) or *mithhi* (sweet)," says a member of the community who did not wish to be quoted.

Home and away

Hussain Shahzad, executive chef of Hunger Inc. Hospitality in Mumbai (of Bombay Canteen and Papa's fame), who grew up in Chennai and now lives in Mumbai, points out that much of Bohra food still exists outside restaurants. He recalls gakhar, a layered wheat bread his mother made while he was growing up in Chennai, somewhere between a thick paratha and a baati, cooked in stages to achieve a crisp exterior and soft centre.

In Mumbai, he speaks of dishes like lacy keema-bhejani patties, where spiced minced meat encases a filling — traditionally goat brain — then is dipped in egg, coated in semolina and fried until the edges turn lacy and crisp. He encounters these in his extended family's homes during Eid, having lived in Mumbai for over a decade now. These are foods that appear on occasion, often on a thaal, rather than on menus.

Even within homes, the food

shifts. "Most of the cooks at home in Chennai have been South Indian," he says, "so that influence creeps in." A biryani might carry curry leaves or a note of tamarind instead of lemon (which is used in Mumbai), small changes that become obvious when compared with versions cooked in Bohra homes in the South.

For Hussain, dum ka roat remains a constant — a dense, semolina-based baked preparation made with ghee, sugar or jaggery, and nuts. In Chennai, it is closely associated with Al Madina Halwa House in Royapettah, where it is baked in large trays, sold by weight or packed into tins. "It retains something of its home-style character even in this more public form," says Hussain.

Mumbai-based Chef Amal Farooque traces her food lineage to the Memon Muslim community, whose roots lie across the Sindh-Kutch-Kathiawar belt. "My father's family is from Kathiawad in Gujarat," she says. "Our food is really a mix of where we've come from."

That mix is most evident in the Eid biryani. "There has to be potato," she says. Memon biryani is layered, usually with mutton, the rice and masala coming together only as it is served. "It is spiced but not harsh, the potatoes soft enough to break easily. Alongside it come dahi ka kachumbar, dahi bada, keema cutlets with crisp edges, and goli kebabs. Dishes like bhoona gosht and akhni — a broth-based pulao — round out the table, with bone-in meat preferred for flavour," says Amal.

A typical Eid spread leans heavily on meat, but lunch tables often include daal gosht, served with basmati rice, sometimes with bottle gourd (doodhi) added.

Across these tables, the food is, quite evidently, shaped by memory as much as by method.





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Joe frames the scale of what followed. “Did we ever genuinely think we could be the biggest band in the world? I think that answer probably comes 10 years later,” he says, pointing to their seminal album *Hysteria* in 1987, which took over three years to complete and went on to sell more than 25 million copies worldwide, producing seven hit singles and remaining on the US charts for over two years. “By the summer of ’88 into the summer of ’89, it’s arguable who was bigger between us and U2,” he says.

The making of *Hysteria* remains central to how the band understood itself, largely because of how many times it nearly came apart. “We weren’t prepared to release *Pyromania* 2; we wanted it to be different, equally as good, if not better,” Joe says, describing a process that involved abandoning early sessions with Jim Steinman

and then restarting momentum when Mutt Lange returned after taking a break from production. The delays were compounded in 1984 when drummer Rick Allen lost his left arm in a car accident, forcing the band to pause recording and later rebuild their approach using electronic drum kits that Allen learned to play with a combination of pedals and acoustic triggers that directly shaped the album’s rhythmic precision.

“The reason it took so long is because we wanted it to be right,” Joe says, reducing the multi-year process and one of the most expensive recording budgets in



Def Leppard fans in India have been waiting for the band for decades after their show in 2008 got cancelled. SPECIAL ARRANGMENT



rock history into a single decision that the band refused to compromise on.

Within that extended timeline, the band’s most iconic track ‘Pour Some

Sugar On Me’ occupies a distinct position, since its almost accidental emergence disrupted the album’s carefully managed progression.

“I just started playing the chorus, when Mutt walked back in from a coffee break and said, ‘what’s that?’. I sang it, and he went, ‘hang on a minute,’” he says, describing how Robert shifted the session toward building a rough version before presenting it to the rest of the band. “He said, ‘this is the best hook I’ve heard for years, trust me,’” Joe adds. “We said, we’ve got some good news and some bad news”, remembering the band’s initial resistance to adding another song after years of recording fatigue, which shifted immediately once they heard the demo.

The track was completed in roughly 10 days, a fraction of the time spent on the rest of the album, and went on to become one of their biggest hits, pushing *Hysteria* back up the charts nearly a year after its release.

Def Leppard’s relationship with India exists in fragments that are

only now being connected through a full tour.

“We came over in 1998 when we did the Indian MTV Awards where we spoke to Sting side-stage before doing a couple of songs, but that’s literally our only experience,” Joe says. The cancelled 2008 shows remain unexplained from his perspective. “I don’t remember why they were cancelled. But it’s nice finally to be able to come down there and do some actual gigs; we did get a flavour that there are fans here and it’s never too late”.

His explanation for the recent surge of legacy rock in India – Guns N’ Roses, Linkin Park, Green Day and the upcoming Scorpions tour among them – is practical. “Bands only go where they’re invited,” he says, reducing the country’s scale into something workable. “You only need 1% of the population, and you’re talking about millions of people. If there are Def Leppard fans in India that have been dying to see us for 30-40 years, then we owe it to ourselves and to our audience to actually be there,” he adds.

India also seems to exist beyond the stage in a smaller ritual the band has carried with them for years. “It’s the one meal at the end of a tour, it will always be Indian, 100%,” he says about their post-gig supper of choice, placing it as a constant across decades of touring regardless of location. His own preference, however, stays measured. “Sav and Phil will ask for a dish that’s as hot as the face of the sun. I’m a huge fan of chicken korma, but I don’t like it too hot,” he chuckles.

Def Leppard is touring India for a three-city headline tour, featuring concerts in Shillong (March 25), Mumbai (March 27), and Bengaluru (March 29). Produced and promoted by BookMyShow Live, this first full-scale Indian tour features opening acts like Indus Creed and Thermal And A Quarter. Tickets are available on BookMyShow.

Grandmom’s gara, now chic

Ashdeen Lilaowala’s Spring 2026 collection features saris inspired by the designer’s extensive Parsi gara archive

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Ashdeen Z Lilaowala loves classics. So much, that for the launch of his new collection, *She Walks in Beauty* (named after Lord Byron’s poem), he traded modern venues for the 100 plus-year-old Albless Baug Parsi Community Centre in Mumbai. Instead of a runway, he went with an intimate salon-style viewing, inspired by the 1850s fashion scene in Paris. This, he believes, was imperative so viewers could get a closer look at the intricate work that went into the garments. Traditional Parsi gara motifs like cranes, chrysanthemums, peonies and spiders fill the body of the saris and line its borders. The work is elaborate but not loud. The pieces are soft yet bold; elegant, and classic, yet modern enough to be worn for a Gen Z wedding or even a night out.

The theme ties in beautifully with the collection which features archive-inspired saris that Ashdeen has collected over the years, through special pieces gifted from family, friends and sourced from other collectors. There are 21 saris in seven designs with a vibrant colour palette in cherry red, purple, burgundy, emerald, and black. The archive also serves as a source of inspiration for the artisans that work on the collections, helping them master signature motifs, effects and techniques that are core to the Parsi gara tradition, says Ashdeen.

For a global audience Largely credited with reviving the Parsi gara embroidery, Ashdeen says he does not like the accolade. “We have made it popular, more contemporary,” he agrees, adding, “We create apparel which is more wearable and across the line. It’s for a



global audience.” What was bought only by older women, is now being bought by the young as well, he observes.

Earlier, it used to be a women-centric craft, and the label also had tunics for children. Men’s wear has recently been added to its fold. “Today men are peacocking in a way they never did before. Their outfits are as heavy. There’s a sense of new found boldness in Indian men to

carry off embroidery and have lot of patterns in their wardrobe, especially at weddings,” says Ashdeen.

Other than saris, Ashdeen’s eponymous label also creates embroidered pants, waistcoats, jackets, gowns, and silhouettes that are Asian to a certain extent, like kimonos for example. He laughs about how he had been apprehensive about the sari gown but ended up creating them anyway. “You



(Clockwise from far left) Saris from the new collection; and the designer. SPECIAL ARRANGMENT

tend to bow when there is pressure,” he laughs and adds that if it was upto him he would have discouraged anyone wearing them.

Ashdeen is rich with anecdotes and information on Parsi culture. When he started the label in 2012, the sole purpose was to take Parsi gara embroidery

as an inspiration and vocabulary to create a new range of saris and embroidery. The focus, he says, was on hand embroidery and “creating beautiful new designs instead of slavishly copying from past designs”.

Putting his textile design skill to good use, Ashdeen eventually incorporated various fabrics and crafts – bandhani, leheriya, Kanjeevaram – into his creations. “The challenge for us is to remain classic even after decades,” he says. A challenge he has probably overcome because, his creations from 10 years ago are still in demand. As part of the “2026 is the new 2016” trend that has been taking over social media, Ashdeen relaunched his collections from 2016. “People still find it wearable and we’ve been getting a good response. These are classics after all,” he smiles.

For details, log on to [ashdeen.com](#)

Colorectal cancer rising among young adults, warn experts

BY Dr. Mohamed Zehran, Senior Consultant Medical Oncologist

Colorectal cancer, traditionally regarded as a disease affecting older adults, is increasingly being diagnosed among younger individuals, prompting oncologists to call for greater awareness of early symptoms and the importance of timely screening.

Dr. Mohamed Zehran, Senior Consultant Medical Oncologist, observes that a growing number of patients in their 30s and early 40s are presenting with advanced disease. “A major reason for delayed diagnosis is the widespread belief that colorectal cancer occurs only in the elderly. This misconception often leads younger patients to ignore early warning signs,” he says.

Changing lifestyle patterns may be contributing to this trend. Diets high in processed foods, physical inactivity, irregular sleep habits, and chronic stress are considered possible risk factors. Family history and genetic predisposition also remain important risk factors, particularly among younger patients.



Dr. Mohamed Zehran
Apollo Speciality Hospital, Chennai

According to Dr. Zehran, symptoms such as persistent changes in bowel habits, blood in the stool, unexplained anaemia, prolonged fatigue, abdominal discomfort, and unexplained weight loss should not be ignored. “These symptoms are often mistaken for benign conditions such as piles, resulting in delays in diagnosis,” he explains.

Early detection significantly improves outcomes. Awareness and timely medical consultation can make a life-saving difference, he adds.

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Four days aboard the Disney Adventure, the conglomerate's largest ship in their fleet and their first in Asia, sent me on philosophical trip about growing up.

At every high point – when actor Robert Downey Jr. unexpectedly arrived to christen the ship on March 4; or when Elsa sang the deeply emotive crescendos of cult-hit 'Let It Go' – I was at a loss for words. Then came the purge, and a snap back to reality.

At the amusement park on the high-seas with 18 decks, one watches a Simba-themed fireworks show with a recorded narration of *The Lion King's* world by Shah Rukh Khan while eating unlimited slices of pepperoni pizza and giving Spider-Man a hug.

All aboard

The ship set sail from Marina Bay Cruise Centre in Singapore on March 5. Over the next four days, the new Disney cruise experience in Asia becomes less like a vacation and more like a carefully orchestrated immersion into a floating world where storytelling never really switches off. The ship can accommodate over 6,000 people, excluding an extensive crew.

My stateroom is the first surprise. Spacious in a way cruise cabins rarely are. They can accommodate up to four.



Cruising on pixie dust

Aboard Disney Cruise Line's Disney Adventure, inaugurated by actor Robert Downey Jr., a four-day voyage pairs dining with Mickey Mouse and the line's first and longest roller coaster



(Clockwise from left) Concierge family staterooms; Miso-glazed sea bass; Disney Cruise Line's Disney Adventure's float out in Germany; Disney Discovery Reef with aquatic characters and nautical stories from Disney; *The Toy Story* Place on board. DISNEY

The ship feels like a destination. There are seven themed areas offering performances, Disney films, arcade games, and the first-ever roller coaster on a Disney Cruise Line ship and the longest at sea, stretching over 250 metres. For those who would like to do it all, four-days do not seem sufficient. The arcade for instance, and the Baymax cinema, operate round-the-clock each day.

The kids' spaces offer immersive environments where children play ping pong, foosball, arcade games, and learn.

Parents I speak to mention, almost with disbelief, how eager their children are to return there each day. This is besides the pools and splash zones on board where so many run around in tutu swim suits.

Entertainment in the evenings is where Disney leans into its legacy. Theatre productions on board are polished to a degree that rivals professional stage shows on land. Original musicals with characters

from different parts of the Disney world, including all your favourite princesses, *Wall-E*, *Coco*, *Encanto*, *Tangled*, and *Frozen*, leave you awestruck. Other premium paid experiences include a luxurious spa, salon, Bacha-coffee-and-croissant date, high-tea at TWG, and shopping for souvenirs in their several retail stores – a capitalist's paradise.

Tucking in

Dining is the great leveller.

On board are seven quick-service restaurants serving burgers, kebabs, Polynesian food, Indian meals, soft serves, boba tea, and pizzas endlessly. Of them, only the bubble tea restaurant is not included in the ticket price.



Do not forget to try the burgers at Ohana's Grill (modelled on the Lilo and Stitch world), and the doner kebabs (with flavoured rice) at Cosmic Kebab, fashioned after Miss Marvel's reality. For those who skip dinner and want to munch on a meal as late as 3am, a 24-hour room service option can be exercised. Free will?

Dining is not just about food though, it is theatre. Each evening, I rotate through different themed restaurants, a signature Disney concept. One night, dinner unfolds alongside an interactive show at Navigator's Club, where Mickey, Minnie and the gang appear as part of a story that evolves between courses. Another evening is more refined, where the focus shifts towards dishes inspired by global cuisines. An elaborate breakfast spread with food from all over the world, including *pesaruttu* and *chole* from India, can be found at the Enchanted Summer Restaurant and Pixar Market Restaurant.

One can also look to book a paid dinner experience at Mike & Sulley's Flavors of Asia for a Japanese meal; and an elaborate Italian meal at Palo Trattoria. Pam Rawlins, executive director, and Salah Chetbi, beverage director, both speak about how this relationship between the servers and the audience tends to add to the experience. Salah says that much of the beverages on board have been inspired by several Asian flavours, adding that he is thrilled to be in 'this part of the world' where ingredients are abundant.

After a while, time begins feeling elastic. I measure my day not by hours, but by experiences – breakfast overlooking the sea, an impromptu character encounter, an unplanned late-night dessert.

After four days of being terribly overstimulated, my phone buzzes back to life as we reach the Singapore port.

The spell begins to lift. But not entirely. I doubt it ever will.

The starting price of a three-night cruise on the Disney Adventure is \$935; and \$1,262 for four nights.

The author was aboard on invitation from Disney Cruise Line.

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Hindi

Prakash Jha’s
game of thrones



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Prakash Jha returns this week to his *Raajneeti* universe with a flawed yet engaging take on benevolence. The series *Sankalp* stands out for its intellectual ambitions and strong performances.

In an era of flashy spectacles, Jha sticks to a traditional, issue-driven style, prioritising realism and complexity, though some methods of portraying power corridors and the dynamics between kingmakers and rebellious disciples now feel clichéd in the series format.

Inspired by the Chanakya-Chandragupta dynamic, *Sankalp* follows Kanhaiyalal, popularly called Ma’at Saab (Nana Patekar), a revered guru in Patna who runs a gurukul-style school and an UPSC coaching centre, strategically grooming loyal students who rise to powerful bureaucratic positions to take on the entrenched, corrupt system.

Tensions escalate when his protégé, IPS officer Aditya Verma (Mohammed Zeeshan Ayyub), begins to question his mentor’s manipulative methods amid a brewing political rivalry with Delhi’s Chief Minister, Prashant Singh (Sanjay Kapoor), and his strategist, Waqar (Neeraj Kabi).

Sankalp

Director: Prakash Jha

Cast: Nana Patekar, Mohammad Zeeshan Ayub, Neeraj Kabi, Sanjay Kapoor, Kubra Sait, Meghna Malik

Synopsis: An enigmatic mentor nursing past peevs builds a covert network of loyal civil servants through a gurukul grooming, extracting absolute pledges of allegiance.

Jha, along with creator-writer Reshu Nath, seems to have built on this character to create the political puppeteer in *Sankalp*. It reminds one of Jayaprakash Narayan, who mentored a new generation of political leaders in the 1970s to take on the Congress. Ma’at Saab does something similar in the bureaucracy as Jha reimagines political succession in a democracy where the *laal batti* of bureaucrats and technocrats is increasingly becoming the guiding light.

However, perhaps in a bid to play safe, Jha doesn’t allow his protagonist to aim big. He just wants to change the Delhi State government. It is a low-hanging fruit for a ten-episode series starring powerhouses such as Patekar, Ayub, and Kabi.

Moreover, after building a riveting world full of intrigue, some ordinary, if not lacklustre, writing disappoints.

What keeps one interested is the larger vision of depicting a world coated in shades of gray, where truth shifts with perspective.

Written with Patekar in mind, *Sankalp* benefits from the master actor’s magnetic presencer. Like a coiled spring, he brings out the quiet authority of Ma’at Saab while giving the audience a sense of menace and tyrannical instincts that such a personality holds beneath layers of calm and warmth.

Sankalp is currently streaming on Amazon MX Player



A cursory Hallyu excursion

As the world continues to embrace the K-Wave, *Made In Korea* feels timely, but its wholesome premise could have benefitted from better execution

Tamil

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After more than four years of watching K-Dramas and seeing K-Pop dominate my annual Spotify Wrapped playlists, I finally had the chance to visit South Korea last year. When I set foot in Seoul, it felt like being in a simulation of sorts as everywhere I looked, I could spot posters of Byeon Woo-seok. Along with that, walking into convenience stores and picking up ramen and banana milk felt exciting, and every time I chanced upon a public landmark that I had spotted on a show, I clicked a dozen photos.

However, in *Made In Korea*, when Shenba (Priyanka Mohan) steps into Seoul, the circumstances might not be ideal. Throughout the duration of her stay there, we don’t quite get a sense of what it is that fascinated her about South Korea, or K-Culture in the first place. There is one song later in the film that shows her visiting all the popular haunts; the Namsan tower and the Lotte World amusement park, but it all feels too fleeting. Why does she love those shows? What is her favourite K-pop group? We never really know.

Growing up in a picturesque town in the hills in Tamil Nadu, Shenba first learns about South Korea during a school fancy dress competition and is fascinated with its possible historical link to her

Made In Korea

Cast: Priyanka Mohan, Park Hye-jin, Baek Si-hoon

Director: Ra Karthik

Genre: Drama

Plot: When a broken heart leads her from Tamil Nadu to South Korea, Shenba embarks on a journey to find community, resilience and identity



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state. This is then a segway into everything K-Culture; she has posters of Lee Min-ho on her bedroom walls, bops to K-pop and of course, tries to learn the language as well. While it makes for a refreshing change that her starting point is this fascination with history, there is little else to go by, even when she does land in Seoul. I smiled during a scene where Shenba walks into a restaurant and confidently asks for a So-Maek(a soju and beer cocktail), something she has undoubtedly picked up from her K-Drama viewing. These moments are few in number.

In an interview to *The Hindu*, director Ra Karthik said that his experiences as a first-timer in Seoul came in handy while shooting the film. These scenes are also the most interesting ones in the film, where we follow Shenba navigate being in a foreign city for the first time. She has to learn to stand in queue for a bus for instance—concepts alien to most of us even in an Indian city. Aided by a kind stranger, a vlogger who soon becomes her first friend in the city, Shenba soon takes up work as a helper in a mansion, tending to a bedridden grandma (Park Hye-jin).

The fact that *Made In Korea* chooses to eschew romance and focuses on how Shenba and her elderly friend set out to reclaim their identity and embark on a journey of self-discovery makes for a welcome writing choice. Many years ago, in the 2013 Hindi film *Queen*, we saw Rani (Kangana Ranaut) re-discover life in Europe. Shenba’s pursuits in Korea aren’t as adventurous, but we still want to root for her.

What could have been a straightforward, wholesome journey of rediscovering oneself and building a community however, feels complicated with the addition of multiple plotpoints. Yes, it is rather convenient how a restaurant quickly comes together, but it would have been more than fulfilling to just watch them thrive at this. We are instead fed another arc about her friends wanting to succeed as singing superstars all of a sudden. I would have much rather enjoyed seeing Shenba trying out more of her recipes like the garlic kimchi fried rice.

Propping all of this up is an earnest Priyanka Mohan, who plays the sweet Shenba with conviction. There’s genuine warmth when she and Hye-jin share screen space, but one wishes the supporting cast also had roles that were written better. We know of them only as acquaintances and remain quite unsure of why the group came together or what they bond over.

As the world embraces the K-Wave a little more with each passing day, discovering a new show, and eagerly waiting for a favourite K-pop group’s comeback, the time feels ripe for a cross-cultural project like this one; a film where the protagonist has a dream shared by scores of people across the world. *Made In Korea* has its heart in the right place and the premise feels fitting; it is the execution that falters.

Made In Korea is currently streaming on Netflix

Nicole Kidman and Jamie Lee Curtis cannot save this murderous mess

English

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Oh dear lord, this was a show I was looking forward to, having read quite a few of Patricia Cornwell’s *Scarpetta* novels. The cast seemed promising, from Nicole Kidman playing the protagonist, the medical examiner Dr Kay Scarpetta, to Bobby Cannavale as Pete Marino, the detective and Scarpetta’s abrasive but heart-in-the-right-place, sidekick.

The tone, however, is all over the place, swinging wildly from graphic, with top shots of nude bodies laid out on autopsy tables, to a grating family drama. The plotting is cluttered, with the switching between two timelines, which, far from adding depth to the characters and showing why they behave the way they do, only muddies the waters further.

The casting also did not work, and the biggest misstep is Jamie Lee



Curtis as Dorothy, Kay’s sister. She is shrill and strident, and Dorothy and Kay’s constant fighting is not engaging at all.

The worst crime in *Scarpetta* is the fact that the writers seem to have forgotten this was meant to be a police procedural and should shine a spotlight on one of the most fascinating investigative processes.

Evidence does not lie, and some

of the charm of the books lies in how Kay and her team of expert witnesses put the forensic evidence together to build a case; be it polished pennies or a practically impossible high shot.

With the introduction of an AI chatbot in the form of Janet (Janet Montgomery), *Scarpetta* decidedly went over to the goofy side and lost whatever semblance of believability

it could lay claim to.

After that, tech companies printing organs, being attacked in space by Russians and peppering a field with organs seemed like another day at the office. Even the red herrings are annoying, just placed for the sake of filling the field.

Kay returns to the Commonwealth of Virginia as the chief medical examiner, a post she held some time ago, before leaving under a cloud of suspicion. A woman’s body is discovered, staged in the same way as it was in Kay’s first case. We go back 27 years to see Kay (Rosy McEwen) as the newly appointed chief facing hostility for her gender (probably).

The city is in panic as a killer attacks and kills women in their houses. Scarpetta meets young Marino (Jacob Lumet Cannavale) and an FBI profiler, and her future husband, Benton Wesley (Hunter Parrish, Simon Baker in the present).

There is an actor who might be the killer in the past and who is doing shady things in the present as well. Kay faces pushback from the smarmy city attorney Bill Boltz (Mike

Vogel). A reporter, Abby (Sosie Bacon), is following the case and pops up at inopportune moments to grill Kay about the case.

We also meet 11-year-old tech genius Lucy (Savannah Lumar), Dorothy’s (Amanda Righetti) daughter, who is staying with Kay as Dorothy has run off with some man. Lucy (Ariana DeBose) continues her computer wizardry, enough to create an AI chat bot of her dead wife, Janet. The way the mystery

unfolds is underwhelming and the unmasking of the killers in both timelines supremely tedious.

The makers have not done right by any of the characters, especially Kay. As far as the cast goes, Bobby Cannavale seems to have the most fun, though there is zero chemistry between him and Curtis, and he looks a far cry from the book Marino. Kidman does not work as Kay, as all she seems to do is stalk through corridors with her coat billowing out behind her wearing a curiously mask-like expression. McEwen, on the other hand, has done a good job of channelling a younger Kidman.

Those who have not read the books would be confused by who is doing what (why does everybody hide information from everyone else?) and those who have read the books will be equally confused about the muddled mess on screen. And a second season is already in production. Sigh.

Scarpetta currently streams on Amazon Prime Video

The Testament of Ann Lee

Director: Mona Fastvold

Cast: Amanda Seyfried, Thomasin McKenzie, Lewis Pullman, Stacy Martin, Matthew Beard, Scott Handy, Viola Prettejohn, Jamie Bogyo, David Cale, Tim Blake Nelson, and Christopher Abbott

Synopsis: In three chapters, the film recounts the story of Ann Lee, the founding leader of the Quakers religious community in the 18th Century



Mona Fastvold's untamed musical

English

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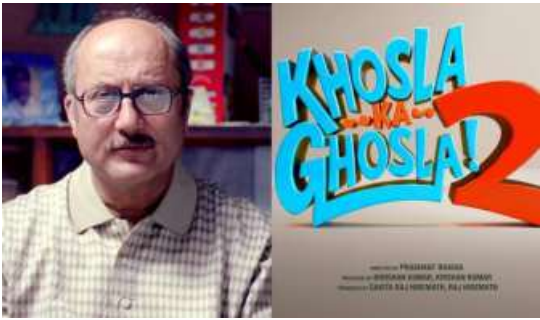
The Testament of Ann Lee begins with a feral promise as we see a group of nuns indulged in a set of ferocious movements that are part of their devotion. Together, they sing a song in praise of the ‘woman clothed by the sun’. In the mystery of a dense forest, their rhythmic movements carry a touch of the supernatural. Until, one amongst them, with a damaged

right eye, breaks away from the band and stands looking right into the camera at us. She is Mary (Mary Partington), the reverential narrator of this musical extravaganza. In her voice, Ann Lee (Amanda Seyfried) becomes a legend. Filmmaker Mona Fastvold envisions Ann's life with the aid of thumping melodies, as the songs encompass the sheer monumentality of her staggering faith. And so, the film is essentially a series of songs that permeate through the extraordinary life led by Ann, from the time she was a girl in Manchester to her transformation into a woman who propagates celibacy and later when she becomes Mother Ann to her followers after receiving frantic visions from God. One night as a child, Ann is disturbed after witnessing her parents engaged in the act and gets violently beaten by her father when she mentions about it at the dining table the next morning. Fastvold rushes through these portions instead of stopping to ponder over the mind of an adolescent Ann.

The film begins to take some coherence later when Ann becomes a member of the group of Shaking Quakers and marries Abraham (Christopher Abbott), whose sadomasochistic tendencies leaves her agonised, as they lose all of their four children. It is only when she is arrested for interrupting the church service that she gets a vision where she sees herself levitating in what is among the most striking imageries of the film. Cinematographer William Rexer films her up-close with a demystifying gravity, concentrating on the fleshly appeal of her body as it experiences a transcendental awakening. That acute sense of palpability extends even to the feverish performance of Amanda. Instead of deifying her presence, Amanda works around to humanise her concerns, channelising an animalistic fervour into her being. All of it ultimately does get tiresome to witness, providing little philosophical inquiry into the magnitude of their faith as Fastvold indulges

more in sensorial satisfaction. That the film's sympathies lie resolutely with Ann also begins to feel limiting. Even her relationship with her brother is not as emotively explored when it seems to form the foundation of the screenplay. As promised in its opening minutes, the film unfolds like a legend, allowing little time to reflect over its immense portrayal of wonder. *The Testament of Ann Lee* works best as a musical performance recounting the life and message of the remarkable woman while lacking the gleam of a steady historical. Even then, its moody design is supremely enchanting. It provokes the heart, shakes the soul, leaving nothing but silence to prevail as it departs in the final frame, much like the mechanisms of such insurmountable devotion – stirring and mesmerising to behold but not as inquisitive in thought. The Testament of Ann Lee was screened at the Red Lorry Film Festival 2026 in Mumbai

Snippets



Anupam Kher's Khosla Ka Ghosla 2 gets release date

The makers of the upcoming comedy-drama, *Khosla Ka Ghosla 2* announced the release date of the film on March 12. It will be released in theatres on August 28. Directed by Prashant Bhagia, the film stars Anupam Kher, Boman Irani, Ranvir Shorey, Parvin Dabas, Vinay Pathak, Tara Sharma and Ravi Kishan. The original, released in 2006, marked the directorial debut of Dibakar Banerjee and was written by Jaideep Sahni. It told the story of Kamal Khosla (Anupam), an ageing patriarch of a middle-class household, who tries to get his land back which was stolen by a crooked builder, Khurana (Boman). *Khosla Ka Ghosla 2* is produced by Bhushan Kumar.



Imtiaz Ali's next with Diljit Dosanjh titled Main Vaapas Aaunga

Main Vaapas Aaunga is the title of acclaimed director Imtiaz Ali's upcoming film with actor-musician Diljit Dosanjh. The film, set to release in theatres on June 12, marks a consecutive collaboration between the actor and the director after *Amar Singh Chamkila*. The title was announced on March 13 with a teaser. In the promo video, Diljit's narrator speaks of a romance that has haunted an elderly man (played by Naseeruddin Shah) for over 78 years. "A story from a dream world," he says as we begin to see glimpses of a love story between Vedang and Sharvari's characters. Vedang, we presume, plays Shah's character's younger version.



Rohit Shetty announces Golmaal 5; Akshay Kumar joins Ajay Devgn

Hindi filmmaker Rohit Shetty announced the much-awaited fifth instalment of the hit comedy franchise *Golmaal* on March 15 on the occasion of his 52nd birthday. Notably, the makers have also announced that superstar Akshay Kumar has joined the cast of the film starring Ajay Devgn. Rohit penned a note along with a special video on Instagram announcing the commencement of the shoot. "20 years ago, the first 'Golmaal' was released, a film that changed my life. The credit goes to you, my audience," he wrote. *Golmaal* is one of the most successful Hindi comedy franchises.



Ildikó Enyedi's sensual wonder

Ildikó Enyedi has created one of the year's most eccentric cinematic seductions — a piece of arboreal erotica that would leave your trees blushing through their leaves

German

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One of my favourite books growing up was Shel Silverstein's *The Giving Tree*. The deceptively gentle tale of a boy growing up alongside a tree proposed a radical idea about companionship – that a tree can observe a human life. Watching Hungarian filmmaker Ildikó Enyedi's *Silent Friend*, I found myself thinking about Silverstein again. A fellow storyteller from Hungarian soil, Enyedi builds an entire feature around that same intergenerational intimacy between humans and plants, imagining a tree as a quiet companion that absorbs anxieties, curiosities and desires without judgement. The film is a triptych that unfolds across more than a century around a single ginkgo tree in the botanical gardens of Philipps University of Marburg, Germany. Each era introduces a new protagonist whose life drifts into orbit around the tree. The cast moves between generations and continents: Tony Leung plays a visiting neuroscientist stranded in Germany during the pandemic, Luna Wedler appears as a pioneering woman student at the university navigating academic hostility in the early 20th century, and Enzo Brumm portrays a shy '70s literature student amidst his romantic awakening. Léa Seydoux, too, appears in a small yet pivotal role as a botanist researching plant communication. Enyedi approaches the material with the same fascination for unseen emotional ecosystems that has defined her oeuvre. The present-day strand belongs to Tony Wong, played by Leung with a melancholic grace that transforms routine gestures into subtler drama. Wong arrives in Marburg to study infant brain activity, only to find his research halted when COVID empties the campus and strands him in near total isolation. The film introduces him wandering through the university as a solitary figure whose curiosity gradually drifts toward the ginkgo tree standing outside the laboratory buildings. Wong

Silent Friend

Director: Ildikó Enyedi

Cast: Tony Leung Chiu-wai, Luna Wedler, Enzo Brumm, Marlene Burow, Lea Seydoux, Sylvester Groth

Storyline: At a German university's botanical garden, an old ginkgo tree serves as the silent witness, linking characters who seek meaning

begins measuring the tree's micro-movements through sensors while corresponding online with Seydoux's French researcher, who studies plant communication. One of the film's most memorable passages arrives early when Wong delivers a lecture on human attention and perception to a small university audience. The lecture explores how consciousness filters reality through selective focus, proposing that entire dimensions of existence remain invisible because human perception has never evolved to register them. Enyedi frames the sequence with a calm clarity, allowing the philosophical ideas to emerge through accessible language and visual illustrations. The film then travels backwards to 1908, where Luna Wedler's Grete enters the university as its first woman science student. Enyedi presents this era in crisp black-and-white cinematography. Her introduction is through a tense university interview where a panel of male chauvinist professors attempts to humiliate her with questions about plant reproduction that quickly slide into invasive speculation about female sexuality. Wedler plays the scene with a clenched fist, answering each question calmly while exposing the intellectual insecurity beneath the professors' authority. Grete's struggle continues when gossip about her chastity forces her from her lodgings, leaving her to moonlight as an assistant to a local photographer whose enthusiasm for the mechanics and artistry of early photography borders on evangelical. The revelation for Grete comes through the act of looking itself. Behind the camera, she transforms various plants and vegetation from academic specimens into subjects of fascination, as her frames isolate their stems, textures and petals with an almost sensual clarity. Enyedi treats photography as liberation for her. The 1972 storyline introduces Enzo Brumm's Hannes, a farm boy studying literature at the university who feels socially out of step with his more politically assertive classmates. His quiet temperament draws the attention of Gundula, a botany student whose experimental apparatus measures the reactions of a geranium placed beside her

window. Their flirtations unfold through playful teasing and shared curiosity until Gundula leaves town briefly and entrusts Hannes with maintaining the experiment. The favour evolves into something more personal as Hannes begins observing the geranium with a mix of scientific attention and emotional projection. Across these three narratives, Enyedi constructs a meditation on humanity's long entanglement with the botanical world. The ever-present ginkgo tree bears witness to intellectual change, observing Grete's struggle for academic recognition, Hannes's tentative curiosity, and Wong's technological experiments in the 21st century. The film frequently reflects on the vulnerability of scientific discovery, which repeatedly encounters scepticism and institutional resistance before new ideas settle into accepted knowledge. Each storyline suggests that knowledge grows through observation, patience and openness to forms of life that human culture has historically overlooked. But what really sneaks up on you in *Silent Friend* is how unexpectedly erotic the entire enterprise becomes once Enyedi lets her thesis run wild. Grete escapes the leering scrutiny of the men around her by turning her gaze toward plants, where the camera allows her to study curves, textures and reproductive mysteries without anyone policing the questions she asks. Hannes channels his infatuation with Gundula into an affectionate attentiveness toward her geranium, watching it with the absorbed delight of a young lover. Wong becomes the logical endpoint of the peculiar ecosystem Enyedi cultivates across her three timelines. When pandemic isolation leaves him with only the tree (and a curmudgeonly gardener) for company, his growing fascination with plant consciousness gradually mutates into what can only be described as a sapiosexual fascination. Enyedi has created one of the year's most eccentric cinematic seductions – a piece of arboreal erotica that would leave your local trees blushing through their leaves.

Silent Friend premiered in Delhi at the Habitat International Film Festival (HIFF)